

Chapter 51_1: Baili Shi Qi

When that movement came, the surroundings became even quieter—not the kind of tranquility that belonged to the night, but an eerie dead silence where not even a whisper of wind could be heard.

Ning Fu Yi knew she had been isolated. She couldn't even sense Chu Qing Qiu's presence from next door. The room seemed to have become a coffin, with something cold and wet falling on Ning Fu Yi's forehead.

Ning Fu Yi opened her eyes to see a blurry figure, seemingly crawling on the ceiling with hands and feet, wearing dirty and torn clothes that emitted a strong stench. The thing appeared to be facing away from Ning Fu Yi, and she could only see a head of seaweed-like pitch-black long hair.

Some pale skin, as if soaked in water, was exposed, with something visibly crawling on it.

What had fallen on her forehead was liquid dripping from that thing. Ning Fu Yi felt nauseated.

As if sensing Ning Fu Yi's gaze, the thing suddenly moved. Accompanied by creaking sounds of friction, what had been the back of its head facing Ning Fu Yi slowly turned around to become a front face.

If an ordinary person had witnessed such a horrifying scene, they would have fainted from fright long ago. However, Ning Fu Yi acted as if she hadn't seen anything and closed her eyes again.

This surprised the thing. The creaking sound stopped abruptly, as if it was stunned in place.

This was undoubtedly a fierce ghost, and this level of ghost was not common. It could even ignore judges¹, and who knew what it had experienced in life to transform into such a powerful vengeful spirit.

But it had no killing intent for the moment, so Ning Fu Yi didn't act rashly. After a while, she suddenly felt her body become light, and the bed beneath her became hard and uncomfortable.

Water droplets pattered down on her face. Thunder rumbled overhead, and several lightning bolts tore through the night sky, illuminating the silent mountain village.

Ning Fu Yi struggled to open her eyes again, only to see that she was lying on a cargo cart pulled by a donkey. The cart creaked along the muddy road, but she couldn't hear the donkey's footsteps. Torrential rain poured down from above, and bean-sized raindrops hit her face painfully. Water fell into her eyes, blurring her surroundings.

Had she been dragged out of the room? Ning Fu Yi thought. She tried to move her fingers but found her whole body rigid. Except for her eyelids, all other limbs couldn't move.

Using immortal power wasn't impossible to break free, but Ning Fu Yi wanted to know where this ghost was taking her. So she didn't move, silently enduring the discomfort of being soaked.

She could see the surrounding scenery from the corner of her eyes. Initially, she was being dragged through the village devoid of human presence, then the cart turned up the mountain, and only the black and white tree shadows under lightning remained before her eyes.

The cart turned another corner. Ning Fu Yi squeezed the water out of her eyes and suddenly felt the road ahead looked familiar.

But before she could see clearly, an ice-blue light suddenly shot out from the bushes, directly smashing the donkey cart beneath Ning Fu Yi into pieces. Ning Fu Yi's heart jumped as her body fell with the collapsing cart. At this moment, another water column wrapped around her body, dragging her toward the bushes.

Water magic—this was a cultivator!?

While Ning Fu Yi's thoughts were racing, that person had already leaped to catch her. At the same time, their right hand made jingling sounds, and the ghost energy became visible. The person shouted sharply: "You stinking ghost, still trying to harm people!"

Then they released Ning Fu Yi and jumped into the forest, chasing after the fierce ghost.

The situation changed instantly. Nearly falling into the grass when the person let go, Ning Fu Yi quickly recited an incantation to break the restraints on her body, then spun twice to steady herself. When she looked up, that person had already disappeared.

Who was this person who had suddenly appeared to block the way? Moreover, judging from those two moves, their cultivation was not low—definitely no less than the Transformation Realm².

Ning Fu Yi was anxious. Without time to wipe the water from her face, she chased in the direction that person had gone.

Water splashed overhead, countless leaves were knocked down by the rain, and tree trunks swayed in the fierce wind like disheveled mad female ghosts. Ning Fu Yi chased for several li³ before finally seeing a human figure.

One person and one ghost were entangled in the mud. Sinister ghost energy mixed with immortal power, uprooting many surrounding trees. Ning Fu Yi summoned Xiangsi⁴ midway to split open half a walnut tree that came flying toward her, finally getting a clearer view of that person.

The person was young, with a tall and graceful figure. Their clothes were soaked by the rain, but the exquisite and luxurious quality was still visible. Their movements always produced jingling sounds—it was the jade ornaments at their waist. Around their neck hung a yingluo⁵ full of spirit stone pendants. Looking at the luster glowing in the storm, any single stone could buy half of Jing Mountain Palace.

This was clearly some wealthy family's young lady. How could she be running to this Axe Head Village in the middle of the night? Ning Fu Yi was puzzled.

However, her cultivation was so high, and the magical tools in her hands seemed divine and powerful. Dealing with a fierce ghost should be more than enough. She probably didn't need to interfere, Ning Fu Yi thought.

But as soon as this thought crossed her mind, she heard the young lady cry out. Lightning illuminated the surroundings, and within her field of vision, the forest was hung with strangely shaped corpses. Ning Fu Yi was immediately horrified.

When she looked back, both the young lady and the fierce ghost had disappeared.

Ning Fu Yi cursed under her breath. She quickly ran to the clearing where the fight had taken place, only to see a scattered yingluo on the ground.

Despite her high cultivation, that young lady was actually a half-baked fighter. Ning Fu Yi was somewhat amused and exasperated. She casually picked up the yingluo from the ground and threw it into her prayer bead⁶, then followed the remaining ghost energy in pursuit.

After a while, she stopped in front of a tall building. The rain had washed away the surface dust, making the red lacquer even more blood-red.

The ghost energy had disappeared here. Before her was that divine temple, pitch black inside where you couldn't see your hand in front of your face. Lightning occasionally lit up, illuminating the clay statues looking down at the ground, their grotesque faces chilling to the heart.

"Xiangsi." Ning Fu Yi spoke softly, and the divine sword understood her meaning, radiating a gentle glow around itself.

Borrowing the sword's light, she stepped into the divine temple. The wind caused the temple door to slam shut suddenly. Ning Fu Yi held her breath but didn't pay much attention, continuing to walk forward slowly.

The divine temple was no different from an ordinary temple. Ning Fu Yi circled around those clay statues and saw nothing. That young lady's presence was completely undetectable, as if she had vanished into thin air.

Could her judgment be wrong? Were they not here? Ning Fu Yi hadn't seen a single ghost shadow, so she finally turned around, planning to go out and search elsewhere.

However, as soon as her hand touched the temple door, she suddenly frowned. A chill rose from behind her, and she immediately turned back, staring at those dozens of divine statues in contemplation.

When she and Chu Qing Qiu had passed by this place yesterday, she had glanced at these divine statues. Although she hadn't counted carefully, it seemed the divine statues yesterday were not arranged as densely as they were now.

So she put down her hand and slowly walked back to the center of the divine temple. Borrowing the divine sword's light to examine carefully, she finally discovered what was wrong. The clay statue in the corner was darker in color than the others. She quickly went forward and wiped it, and sure enough, she felt a handful of half-dry mud.

Her heart was shocked. She quickly slapped it with her palm. The clay statue's outer shell immediately shattered into pieces, and a person softly fell out from inside, rolling to the ground.

Although the face and head were covered with mud, judging from the clothes, it was indeed the young lady from earlier.

Ning Fu Yi quickly patted her face twice. The person immediately took a sharp breath and bounced up like a corpse coming back to life, staring at Ning Fu Yi about to scream.

Ning Fu Yi quickly covered her mouth: "It's me, shh!"

Only then did the young lady blink and recognize that Ning Fu Yi was the person she had just saved. Her body went limp as she sat down, clutching her chest and breathing heavily.

"Are you also a cultivator? Which sect are you from, fellow daoist?" The young lady used her sleeve to wipe the mud from her face, revealing the tender skin underneath. Her face was round like a red fruit, with some baby fat, yet small and delicate like a melon seed—beautiful and lively.

"I am a rogue cultivator." Not knowing the other party's intentions, Ning Fu Yi didn't reveal her identity and just answered casually, standing up to examine the remaining divine statues.

It seemed that what the nursery rhyme sang about "playing with mud" meant sealing people in these clay statues. No wonder the villagers said that those marked with "four" all disappeared without a trace.

Most villagers were ignorant and believed in gods descending to earth. Even if these divine statues increased day by day, probably no one would dare to offend them by coming to investigate.

If those villagers knew that the divine statues they worshipped daily were actually corpses, who knew what they would think.

While Ning Fu Yi was thinking this, she suddenly waved her hand, and another divine statue before her shed its shell. However, perhaps because it had been placed for a long time, the outer clay had completely fused with the person inside. When the clay statue shattered like this, it split the corpse inside into several pieces. The stench accompanied scarlet blood flowing out, and the young lady beside her suddenly covered her mouth and started retching.

Ning Fu Yi also covered her nose, her eyes scanning those divine statues one by one.

"Fellow daoist has excellent skills." After retching for a long time without producing anything, the young lady came up to chat with Ning Fu Yi. Although there was fear in her eyes, there seemed to be more excitement, her gaze glancing intensely at the corpse on the ground.

Ning Fu Yi didn't say much to her, walking forward alone to examine those divine statues. But the young lady opened her chatterbox behind her.

"This is the first time in my life I've left home to train. I heard from afar that this Axe Head Village was haunted, so I rushed here through the night in the rain. I didn't expect to encounter this fierce ghost and fought with it for quite a while. Unfortunately, this fierce ghost was truly formidable, and it got the better of me..."

Ning Fu Yi didn't have the heart to tell her that it wasn't a fight at all—she was clearly being beaten up by a ghost.

"I see fellow daoist seems completely unafraid. I wonder what cultivation level fellow daoist has?" The young lady followed behind Ning Fu Yi, her almond eyes like two stars.

Who would ask about someone's cultivation level right off the bat? Ning Fu Yi was somewhat displeased. So with a cold face, she replied: "What's your cultivation level? How could you not defeat a single ghost?"

She intentionally confronted her to make her quiet down for a while, but unexpectedly the young lady didn't hear the unfriendliness in her words at all. Instead, she smiled without guard: "My name is Baili Shi Qi⁷. You can just call me Shi Qi. My home is in Penglai Realm⁸. I just broke through to the Transformation Realm a few days ago and snuck out to train!"

Ning Fu Yi was momentarily speechless. She hadn't expected the young lady to actually answer truthfully. In all her years wandering the jianghu⁹, this was the first time she'd met someone who revealed their background and cultivation level right from the start.

The surname Baili only existed in Penglai, and it was the surname of the lineage of Penglai's ruler, the Heavenly Auspicious Emperor. This young lady before her indeed had a noble status.

What a pity that with such a good family background, her brain wasn't very useful.

Footnotes:

1. **Judges (判官):** Officials in the underworld who decide the fate of souls after death in Chinese mythology
2. **Transformation Realm (化境):** A cultivation level in the established power system where cultivators undergo significant transformation
3. **Li (里):** Traditional Chinese unit of distance, approximately 500 meters
4. **Xiangsi (相思):** The name of Ning Fu Yi's divine sword, meaning "longing" or "lovesickness"
5. **Yingluo (璎珞):** A type of traditional Chinese jewelry consisting of beaded necklaces or ornamental chains
6. **Prayer bead (一念珠):** A magical storage item that can shrink and hold objects
7. **Baili Shi Qi (百里拾七):** Literally means "Baili Seventeen," indicating she's the seventeenth child or her birth order
8. **Penglai Realm (蓬莱境):** One of the immortal realms, based on the mythical Penglai Island
9. **Jianghu (江湖):** The world of martial artists and cultivators; literally means "rivers and lakes"